



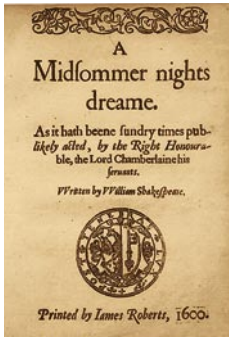
17th-century image of a compositor laying out letters for printing

Book publishing

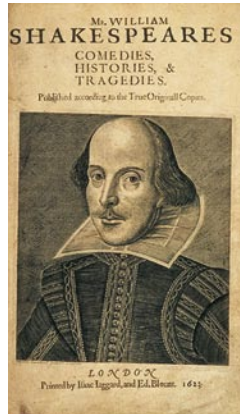
BY THE TIME Shakespeare was writing, all kinds of books were being mass-produced in print shops all over Europe; but he had little interest in seeing his plays in print. They were written to be performed and could reach a far larger audience at the Globe than they would as books. Shakespeare's plays belonged to his company, and about half of them were published during his lifetime as little books called quartos. They were published when their performing days were over, or when the company needed to raise money. It was not until seven years after his death that some fellow actors published Shakespeare's plays in a single volume which is known as the First Folio.

HARD PRESSED

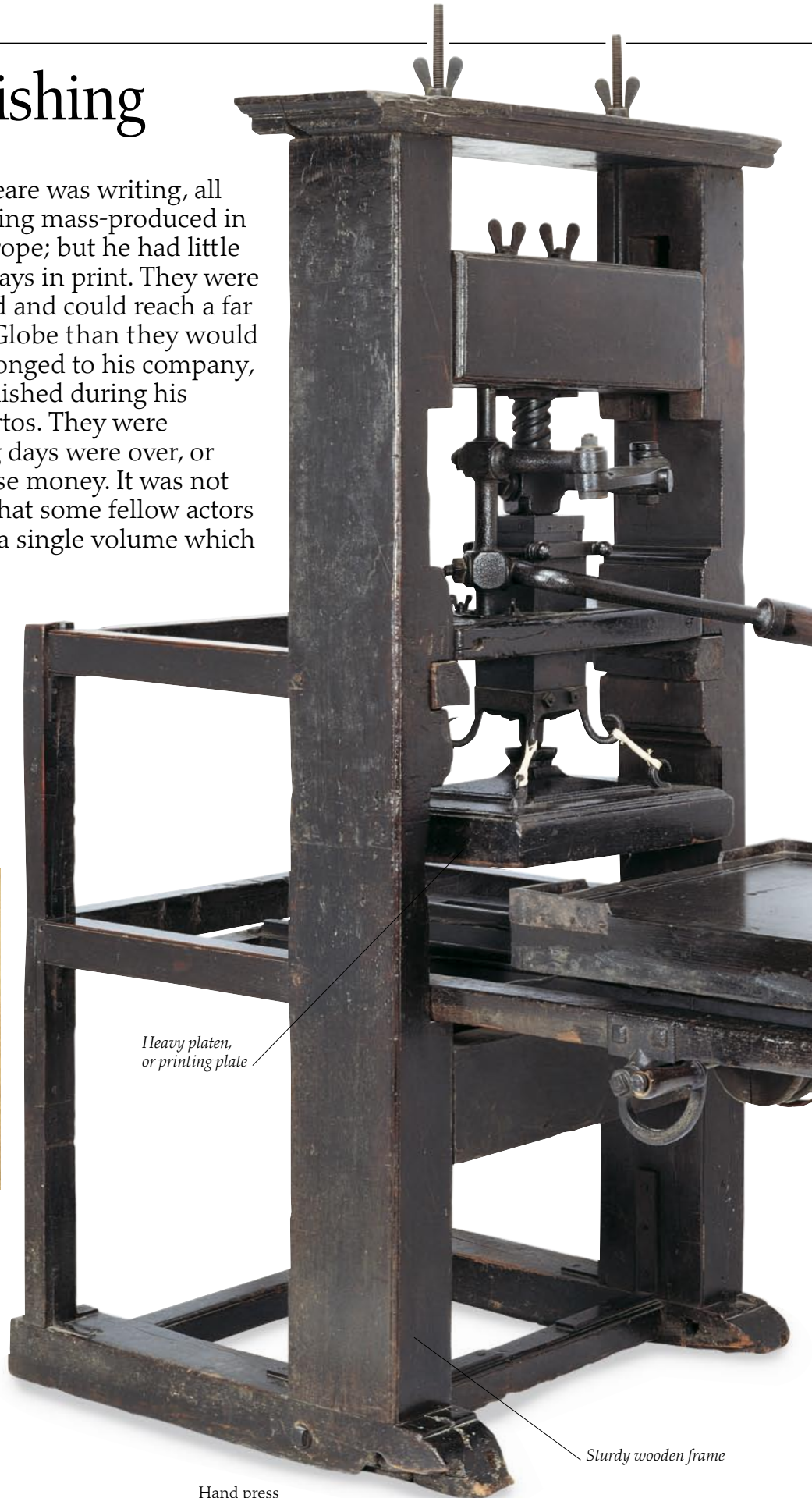
The printing process in Shakespeare's day was long and slow, and required the input of several people. A pressman called a compositor laid metal letters in a frame called a chase. This was placed on the "coffin," where a pressman inked the letters with a leather ball. Another pressman placed the paper on a frame called a tympan, and lowered it on to the coffin. He then slid the coffin under a printing plate called a platen, and pulled the bar to lower the platen, pressing the paper onto the inky letters.



SIXPENNY QUARTO
This edition of *A Midsummer Night's Dream* was printed in 1600 by James Roberts, one of 21 printers in London at the time. Each copy was sold for six pennies – six times the cost of seeing the play on stage. The name quarto, meaning fourth, comes from the fact that four pages were printed at once, on each side of a single sheet. This was folded twice and cut to make eight pages of text.



FIRST FOLIO
In 1623, Henry Condell and John Heminges published 36 of Shakespeare's plays in the leather-bound First Folio. A folio, from the Latin word for leaf, is a large book with pages made up of standard sheets, or leaves, of paper folded in half. Hemmings and Condell wrote that their aim was "only to keep the memory of so worthy a friend, and fellow alive, as was our Shakespeare."



Heavy platen, or printing plate

Sturdy wooden frame

Hand press